

TURNIPS *Brassica campestris* Rapifera Group

Grown like root vegetables but members of the brassica family, turnips are an often overlooked crop. Harvested young, their roots have a delicious nutty flavor and are excellent cooked or eaten raw. Also try harvesting the spicy young leaves, or “turnip tops,” and cook as spring greens. There are many unusual varieties that are well worth trying, in a variety of striking colors, such as black, purple, and white.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW/PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Turnips will grow well in most soils, but they require high levels of nitrogen and a pH of between 5.5–7.5. Dig in some well-rotted manure or compost the fall before planting.

Sow four seeds to a cell in module trays and transplant each group when seedlings have grown two or three true leaves each. Protect seedlings from frost. Alternatively, sow seeds directly into the ground in early spring; they are less likely to germinate in later months when the weather warms up. To avoid a glut, sow successively every few weeks. Scatter seeds thinly along rows 9–12 in (23–30 cm) apart, or in blocks with 6 in (15 cm) spacing. Cover with .75 in (2 cm) of soil



Plant out module-grown crops in spring.

and water in. Thin seedlings to 4–6 in (10–15 cm) apart before they are more than 1 in (2.5 cm) tall. For turnip tops, sow in late summer, early fall, or early spring.

CROP CARE

Keep plants weeded and well-watered, especially during the summer, to prevent them from bolting. Turnips should not need an additional feed during growth.